



PINE Case Study

It's Elementary: Understanding Neurodiversity Among Grade-School Students

Empowering elementary school educators with a deeper understanding of — and empathy for — their young pupils.

Minoa Elementary School Principal Gary Gerst has a practical reason for wearing sneakers to work. On the rare occasion that a young student decides to run away from the upstate New York k-5 school, Gerst can sprint after him more easily in kicks than in loafers. One recent Friday morning, an autistic student did attempt such an escape, only to be swiftly intercepted by Gerst.

Arguably, blocking a pint-sized pupil from a school exit is the easier part of Gerst's job. The harder one? Understanding what prompted him to run in the first place. Like many schools across the country, Minoa Elementary has seen an uptick in the number of neurodivergent children who are autistic or are classified as having ADHD. And, as in many other places, Gerst and his staff have had trouble grasping and meeting their needs.

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A lack of training, Gerst says, is central to the problem. Gerst, himself a former director of special education, notes that standard professional development for teachers yields little in the way of substantive information on understanding neurodiversity. Without such information, many educators are limited in how well they can relate to their neurodivergent students. For example, some have found it difficult to comprehend how autistic students could excel at reaching certain academic benchmarks yet struggle interacting with their peers or experience seemingly inexplicable meltdowns.

“Say you have a child who is in second grade, who is counting to 100, who knows their letters and is reading beautifully. You're thinking to yourself that this child should be able to do everything else,” Gerst explains. “I've found that 99% of the teachers that I work with, they want to do the right thing and work with the kids. But, as educators, we're often left in our rooms by ourselves trying to figure things out and we fall back on the traditional things we've done in the past...and then nothing changes.”



But Minoa school officials soon found that change was indeed possible...with the right partners.

Working With PINE

Gerst turned to the Program for Inclusion and Neurodiversity Education (PINE) to give Minoa faculty and staff critical support to work with their neurodiverse student population. Gerst and members of his leadership team met with PINE consultants in August 2022.

Part of PINE's appeal, Gerst says, was that it's not a "one-and-done" program. "We know that one-and-done workshops don't work," he says. "You need really high-quality professional development that's ongoing." But ongoing development takes time, so Minoa officials and the PINE team brainstormed how to ensure that Minoa educators had the time to take on PINE training.

Their solution? To block out an hour each month for teachers and staff to access PINE's online learning platform. During those hours, the school hired substitutes to cover teachers' classes. "It's allowed teachers to do things within the contractual day, right as school is going on," Gerst says.

Minoa educators began their PINE training with the platform's Understanding Autism course. The course, consisting of seven modules, is designed to help professionals shift their mindsets on autism and disabilities, encourage them to reflect on their biases and preconceptions, learn to celebrate neurodiversity, and understand how to leverage their students' strengths.

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As Minoa teachers and staff engaged with the modules, the coursework became a focal point at faculty meetings. Educators, for instance, held a rich discussion about the course's survey on personality types. The purpose of the survey is to show "there is inherent diversity and difference among any group, without pathologizing it," explains Samara Sweig, vice president of business strategy and operation at PINE. "It helps level the playing field."

"It was an awesome way to start the course out because it was a great indicator of how differently our minds work," Gerst adds.

Minoa teachers and staff also attended the annual PINE summit, a virtual three-day conference featuring presentations from experts in special education, communication, and inclusion. (See sidebar below)



The PINE Summit: Energizing Educators with New Insights

The annual PINE Summit gives participants the opportunity to dive deeper into subjects covered in PINE coursework. The 2023 summit included presentations on augmentative and alternative communication (AAC), sensory safety at school, designing inclusive learning environments, managing stress in the classroom, and strategies for parents to support neurodivergent children at home.

Gerst says the summit was eye-opening for Minoa educators. The Sensory Safety presentation focused

on school as a sensory environment and how educators need to think about creating a sense of safety for students with sensory differences. And the session on teaching for Universal Design for Learning gave faculty a wealth of ideas on what they can improve in their own lesson planning and teaching, which focused on a framework known as Universal Design for Learning, gave faculty a wealth of ideas on what they can improve in their own classrooms, from using dimmer settings on overhead lights to implementing specific instructional strategies.

The AAC presentations, meanwhile, illuminated the often-hidden potential of nonspeaking students. The presenters, who included nonspeaking adults using communication devices, demonstrated that nonverbal students can learn and achieve far more than casual observers might assume.

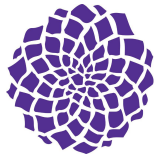
After the summit, “there was definitely a buzz in the building,” Gerst says. “People were asking, ‘Hey, did you see this? Did you see that?’” The conference, he says, could turn even the most pessimistic educator into a “believer.”

Presuming Competence and Helping More Students

Gerst says that after their first school year spent working with PINE, Minoa educators are growing increasingly adept at presuming the competence of their students, empowering them to make the most of children’s strengths and interests for better learning outcomes. A student with a special interest in the sinking of the Titanic, for example, could be excited to work on math word problems that mention the ill-fated ship. A student who loves reading detective novels may be more inclined to practice their writing skills if assigned to create mystery stories of their own.

Teachers and staff have also become more attuned to the fact that students’ “misbehavior” is often a type of communication, rather than a sign of disrespect. Acting out or disrupting a class may be a student’s way of communicating that something is triggering them. By addressing those triggers — whether it’s a loud noise or distracting room décor — educators are helping students feel more comfortable and able to learn.

“We’re trying to change from a very traditional mindset where, if you see a student struggling, instead of fighting it, you recognize it and say, ‘How can we help?’” Gerst says. “We’re becoming more flexible and we’re developing more empathy.”



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But there's still more work to be done.

In the coming school year, Gerst and his staff intend to take further advantage of PINE, with plans to incorporate discussions of PINE strategies in Professional Learning Communities — groups of teachers in the same grade who meet regularly to discuss grade-level instruction — and to proactively use the resources in PINE's online library to help students at risk of failing their classes, whether they're diagnosed as neurodiverse or not.

"This program is good for all kids," Gerst says. "We haven't even scratched the surface yet."